Chandra Shekhar was not an intellectual like Gujral with high- flying ideas. He was a hard-nosed politician who had knowledge of global issues thanks to long parliamentary experience. According to a former confidant of his, Chandra Shekhar was a quick decision maker who did not like to dither. For example, he decided to allow refuelling facilities to US aircraft in exercise of his executive authority without seeking a decision from the cabinet committee. Even after criticism, Chandra Shekhar stuck to his decision as he believed it was in India's interest to help a friendly country. Once he took the decision he was strong enough to stand up to any criticism by parliament and public opinion.[130] It helped that he knew he could not survive in office after another general election, which was forced by the instability of coalition politics in the summer of 1991.

The 1991 election might have yielded another hung parliament had it not been for the tragedy of Rajiv Gandhi's assassination during the course of the election campaign. A sympathy wave catapulted the Congress party to power and a veteran Congress politician from India's south, P.V. Narasimha Rao became India's next prime minister. Rao was a consummate insider who had served as minister for external affairs under both Indira and Rajiv Gandhi (1980–84 and 1988–89). Now he led as prime minister at a critical juncture in Indian politics as the first person outside the Nehru-Gandhi family to govern for a full five-year parliamentary term (1991–96).

Dixit refers to Rao 'as one of the most effective and creative influences' on Indian foreign policy.[131] Rao became prime minister at a time of domestic upheaval. Rajiv Gandhi had just been assassinated, the Congress party faced divisions in the absence of a towering figure or a scion of the Nehru-Gandhi family and domestic politics was unstable as new regional parties emerged as power brokers. Rao also had to contend with far-reaching changes in the global order marked by the end of the cold war, the coming down of the Berlin Wall and the disintegration of the Soviet Union.